

Day 1: Check-up: what Grade 5 left behind

Bridge · about 40 minutes: warm-up 5 · teach 10 · together 10 · on his own 12 · game 3

1 · WARM-UP (5 MIN)

The check-up in Philip's corner.

2 · TEACH (10 MIN)

Say: “Grade 6 is where theory turns into real music-making: you'll write harmony and compose melodies. First, let's see what Grade 5 left in your head.”

- No new teaching. The check-up in Philip's corner covers Grade 5 chords, intervals, keys, transposition and terms, plus a first look at Grade 6 questions.
- Grade 6 is a different kind of exam: 3 hours on paper, out of 100 (pass 66, merit 80, distinction 90). Half of it is writing music: harmonising a melody, realising a figured bass and composing a melody. The other half is questions on printed scores.
- For looking things up, the Grade 6 reference book (Papers list) has the figures, chords of a key, progressions, the part-writing checklist, notes outside the chord, related keys, devices and the orchestra.

Worked example

What does the Grade 6 paper look like?

1. Question 1 (15): realise a figured bass, in four parts or keyboard style.
2. Question 2 (15): chords for a melody, or a bass line with figures.
3. Question 3 (20): continue an opening to make a melody for an instrument.
4. Questions 4 and 5 (25 each): questions on a score and an orchestral score.

Watch out for

- Expecting it to be like Grade 5: there's no multiple choice in the real paper, so answers must be written precisely.
- Rushing the check-up: it's only useful if it's honest.

In the exam: The paper is 3 hours, marked out of 100, sat in an exam centre.

Show him these cards

1

Grade 6 is a new kind of exam: 3 hours, on paper, out of 100. You need 66 to pass, 80 for merit and 90 for distinction.

2

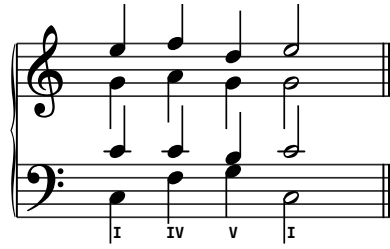
Half the marks are for WRITING music: chords for a melody, four-part harmony from a figured bass, and composing a melody.

3

The other half is questions on printed scores: chords, keys, intervals, instruments and terms.

4

Today: a check-up, so we know what you remember from Grade 5.



3 · DO TOGETHER (10 MIN)

- Look at a Grade 6 question together (the lesson pack has one) and talk about what it asks.

Four questions to work through together

1. Which cadence is this?

IV-I

- A. perfect B. plagal C. imperfect

Answer: plagal. IV-I is a plagal cadence, the 'Amen' ending.

2. What is the technical name of degree 5?

- A. tonic B. leading note C. dominant D. mediant

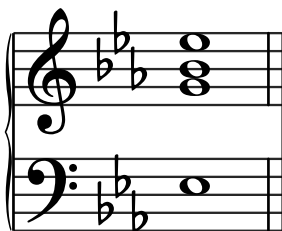
Answer: dominant. Degree 5 is the dominant.

3. Which note is in the bass of Vc in G major?

- A. D B. F# C. C D. A

Answer: A. V = D-F#-A. "c" means second inversion, so the 5th is in the bass: A.

4. Name this chord in E $\flat$ major. Use the numeral and a, b or c.



- A. IIa B. Ib C. Ia D. Ic

Answer: Ia. Put the notes in 3rds: E $\flat$ -G-B $\flat$. The root is E $\flat$, degree 1, so it's chord I. The lowest note, in the bass stave, is E $\flat$: the root, so a.

4 · ON HIS OWN (12 MIN)

- The 24-question check-up in Philip's corner.

His worksheet is on the next page (answers at the end).

5 · GAME (3 MIN)

Name that chord: you play I, IV or V on the piano; he names it.

MOVE ON WHEN

The check-up is done and the Mastery tracker is set. Anything red gets an extra look in the next days.

Philip's worksheet · Day 1

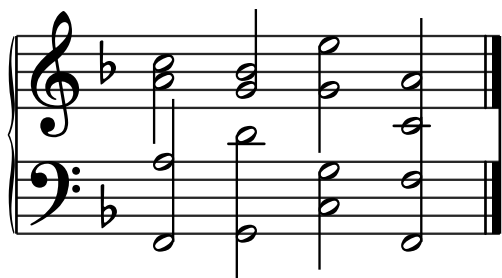
Name _____ Date _____ Score ____ / 8

1. These are the last two melody notes of a phrase in C major. Which chords make a perfect cadence?



- A. I-V B. IV-V C. V-I D. II-V

2. This phrase is in F major, for four voices. Which cadence ends it?



- A. imperfect B. plagal C. perfect

3. This phrase is in D major, for four voices. Which cadence ends it?



- A. imperfect B. perfect C. plagal

4. This is a tonic triad. Which key is it in?

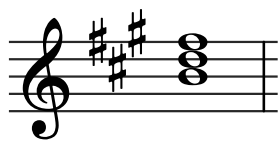


- A. E major B. A major C. B major D. E $\flat$ major

5. Spell chord V in C# minor.

- A. E-G#-B# B. F#-A-C# C. G#-B#-D# D. D#-F#-A

6. Name this chord in A major.



A. IIa

B. IVa

C. Va

D. IVc

7. These are the last two melody notes of a phrase in F major. Which chords make a plagal cadence?



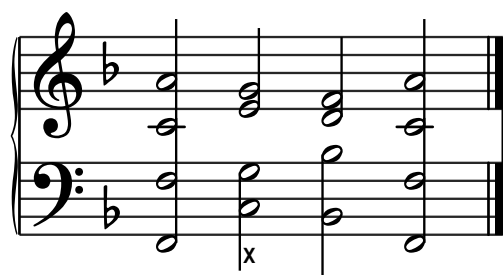
A. IV-I

B. II-V

C. IV-V

D. I-V

8. This phrase is in F major, for four voices. Name the chord marked X.



A. II

B. V

C. IV

D. I

ANSWERS (FOR MUM)

1. **C: V-I.** The first note, G, is in chord V (G-B-D). The second, C, is in chord I (C-E-G). V-I makes a perfect cadence.
2. **C: perfect.** The last two chords are V (C-E-G) and I (F-A-C). V-I is perfect.
3. **A: imperfect.** The last two chords are I (D-F-A) and V (A-C-E). Ending on V is imperfect.
4. **B: A major.** The bottom note is the tonic, A. With this key signature, that makes it the tonic triad of A major.
5. **C: G#-B#-D#.** Chord V is built on degree 5, the dominant: G#-B#-D#. In a minor key V uses the raised 7th.
6. **A: Ila.** The notes are B-D-F#, built on degree 2, so it's II. The bass note is B, the root, so root position (a).
7. **A: IV-I.** The first note, D, is in chord IV (Bb-D-F). The second, F, is in chord I (F-A-C). IV-I makes a plagal cadence.
8. **B: V.** Chord X has the notes C-E-G (the bass is C), so it's chord V.

Day 2: Triads on every note: Roman numerals in major and minor

Bridge · about 40 minutes: warm-up 5 · teach 10 · together 10 · on his own 12 · game 3

1 · WARM-UP (5 MIN)

Today's practice in Philip's corner, or the first two 'together' questions below.

2 · TEACH (10 MIN)

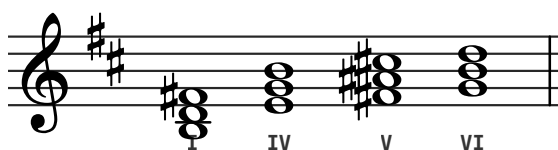
Say: "Every note of the scale can carry a chord. The numbers tell us where we are in the key: I is home, V is the strongest pull back home, IV and II lead towards V."

- A triad is three notes a 3rd apart, built on any note of the scale. Its Roman numeral says which note: I on the tonic, II on the supertonic, up to VII.
- In a major key: I, IV and V are major; II, III and VI are minor; VII is diminished.
- In a minor key we use the harmonic minor, so V is major (raised leading note) and VII is diminished. II is diminished too, which is why it's almost always used as IIb. Avoid III in minor.
- The three most important chords are I, IV and V. II and VI are their close relatives: II often replaces IV, and VI often replaces I.

Worked example

Write chords I, IV, V and VI in B minor.

1. B minor has two sharps: F# and C#. Its leading note is A, raised to A#.
2. I: B-D-F#. IV: E-G-B. VI: G-B-D.
3. V: F#-A#-C#. The A# needs an accidental every time.



Watch out for

- Forgetting the raised leading note in minor-key V and VII.
- Calling II major in a major key: it's minor.

In the exam: Every harmony question assumes you can build any chord in any key up to about four sharps or flats, instantly.

Show him these cards

1

A triad is three notes stacked in 3rds. You can build one on every

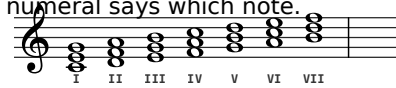
2

In a major key: I, IV and V are major. II, III and VI are minor. VII is diminished.

3

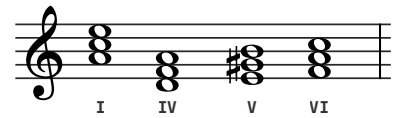
In a minor key, use the harmonic minor: raise the 7th. So V is major (E-G#-B in A minor).

note of the scale. The Roman numeral says which note.



4

In a minor key, II is diminished (B-D-F in A minor), so we use it as IIb. Avoid III in minor.

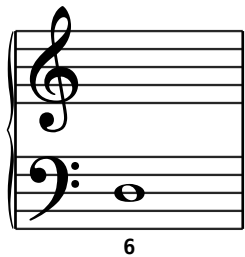


3 · DO TOGETHER (10 MIN)

- Write the triads I to VII in D major and in B minor, and say whether each is major, minor or diminished.
- Play each one on the piano and listen to its colour.

Four questions to work through together

1. In A minor, which chord does this bass note and figure show?



A. IIb

B. Ic

C. Ib

D. IVb

Answer: IIb. D with "6" is IIb: B-D-F.

2. These are the last two melody notes of a phrase in G major. Which chords make a plagal cadence?



A. IV-V

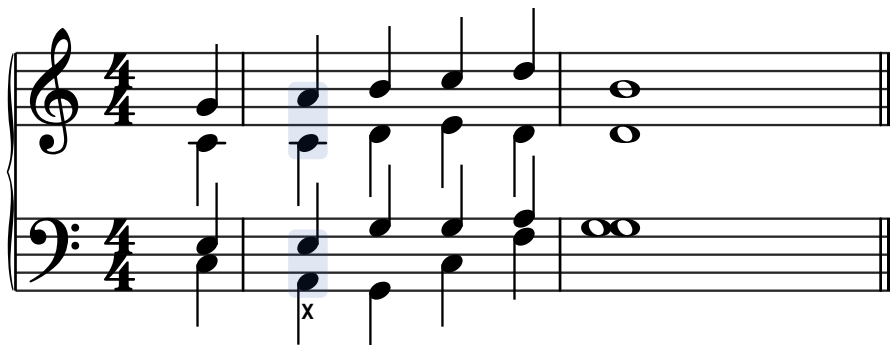
B. I-V

C. IV-I

D. II-V

Answer: IV-I. The first note, C, is in chord IV (C-E-G). The second, B, is in chord I (G-B-D). IV-I makes a plagal cadence.

3. This passage is in C major. Name the chord marked X.



A. Ic

B. VI

C. II

D. V

Answer: VI. X is A-C-E with A in the bass: VI (root position).

4. Name this chord in E minor. Use the numeral and a, b or c.



A. Vc

B. IIc

C. IIa

D. Ib

Answer: IIc. Put the notes in 3rds: F#-A-C. The root is F#, degree 2, so it's chord II. The lowest note, in the bass stave, is C: the 5th, so c.

4 • ON HIS OWN (12 MIN)

- Write triads I, II, IV, V and VI in three keys from the lesson pack.

His worksheet is on the next page (answers at the end).

5 • GAME (3 MIN)

Chord colours: you play a triad; he says major, minor or diminished.

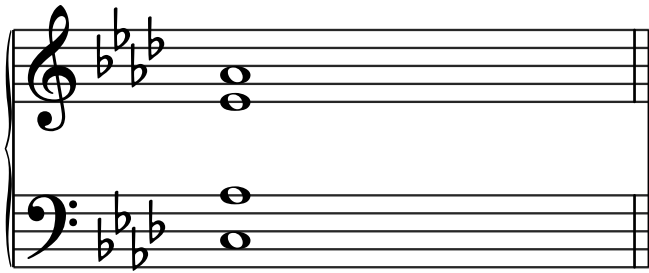
MOVE ON WHEN

He can build and name any triad in a major or minor key, with the right accidentals in minor.

Philip's worksheet · Day 2

Name _____ Date _____ Score ____ / 8

1. Which figures go under this chord? (Key: A $\flat$ major)



A. 6

B. 6/4

C. 5/3 (no figure)

2. These are the last two chords of a piece in F major. Which cadence is it?

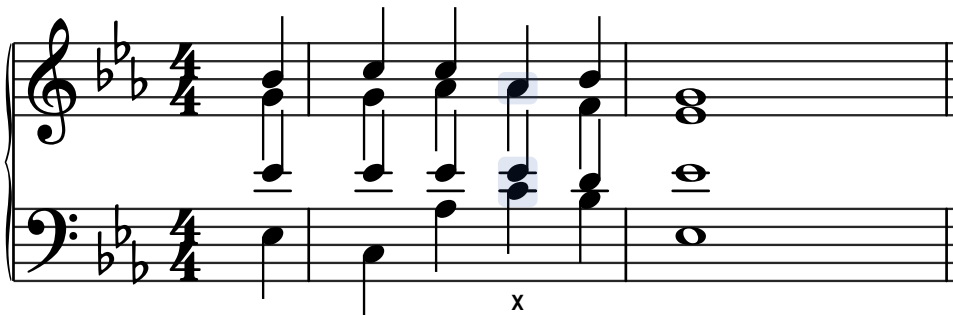


A. plagal

B. perfect

C. imperfect

3. This passage is in E $\flat$ major. Name the chord marked X.



A. IV

B. I $\flat$ c

C. II

D. IV $\flat$

4. These are the last two melody notes of a phrase in F major. Which chords make a perfect cadence?



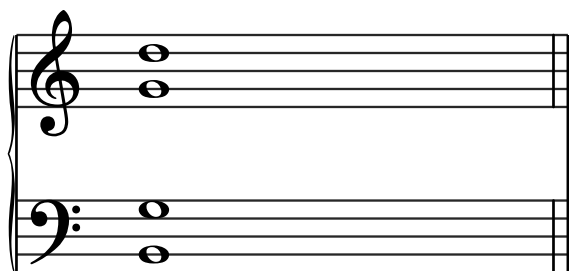
A. IV-I

B. V-I

C. I-V

D. II-V

5. Which figures go under this chord? (Key: C major)

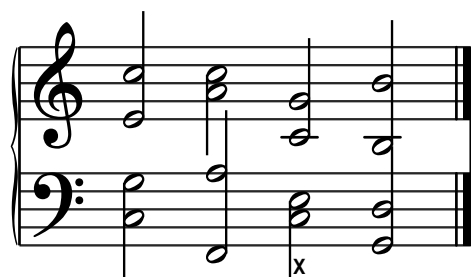


A. 6

B. 6/4

C. 5/3 (no figure)

6. This phrase is in C major, for four voices. Name the chord marked X.



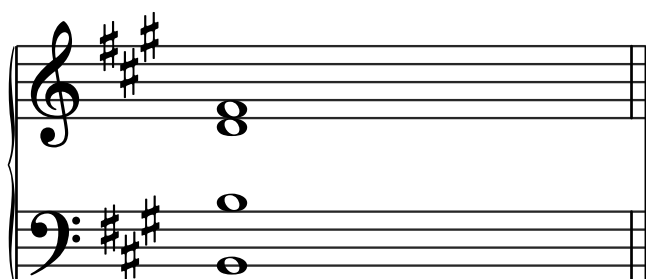
A. I

B. IV

C. II

D. V

7. Which figures go under this chord? (Key: F# minor)



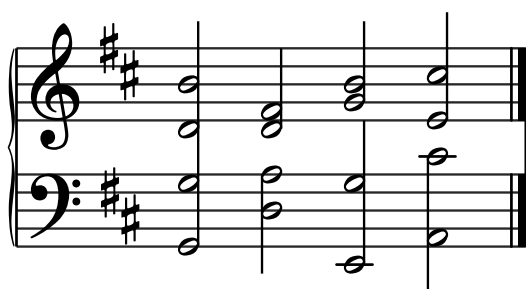
A. #

B. #6

C. 5/3 (no figure)

D. #6/4

8. This phrase is in D major, for four voices. Which cadence ends it?



A. plagal

B. imperfect

C. perfect

ANSWERS (FOR MUM)

1. **A: 6.** The chord is Ib ($A\flat$ -C- $E\flat$) with C in the bass. Count up from the bass: 6.
2. **C: imperfect.** The chords are IV ($B\flat$ -D-F) then V (C-E-G). Ending on V is imperfect.
3. **D: IVb.** X is $A\flat$ -C- $E\flat$ with C in the bass: IVb (first inversion).
4. **B: V-I.** The first note, E, is in chord V (C-E-G). The second, A, is in chord I (F-A-C). V-I makes a perfect cadence.
5. **A: 6.** The chord is Vb (G-B-D) with B in the bass. Count up from the bass: 6.
6. **A: I.** Chord X has the notes C-E-G (the bass is C), so it's chord I.
7. **C: 5/3 (no figure).** The chord is IV (B-D- $F\sharp$) with B in the bass. Count up from the bass: 5 and 3, which is normally left blank.
8. **B: imperfect.** The last two chords are II (E-G-B) and V (A -C $\sharp$ -E). Ending on V is imperfect.

Day 3: Inversions and figured bass: 5/3, 6/3 and 6/4

Bridge · about 40 minutes: warm-up 5 · teach 10 · together 10 · on his own 12 · game 3

1 · WARM-UP (5 MIN)

Today's practice in Philip's corner, or the first two 'together' questions below.

2 · TEACH (10 MIN)

Say: "Figured bass is musical shorthand from 300 years ago: the bass line plus numbers, and the keyboard player filled in the chords. Today you learn to read it."

- Root position: the root is in the bass (a). First inversion: the 3rd is in the bass (b). Second inversion: the 5th is in the bass (c).
- Figured bass counts intervals up from the BASS note, not from the root. Root position is 5/3 (usually left blank). First inversion is 6/3 (written just 6). Second inversion is 6/4.
- An accidental in the figures changes that note. An accidental on its own ($\sharp$ or $\flat$) means the 3rd above the bass: in minor keys, V needs it for the raised leading note.
- To read a figure: start on the bass note, count up the intervals shown, using the key signature unless an accidental says otherwise.

Worked example

In G major, the bass is B with a 6. What chord is it?

1. Count up from B: a 3rd is D, a 6th is G.
2. So the notes are B, D and G: a G major chord.
3. B is the 3rd of G major, so it's first inversion: Ib.

Watch out for

- Counting from the root instead of the bass.
- Forgetting that a lone $\sharp$ or $\flat$ means the 3rd above the bass.

In the exam: Figures appear in question 1, and you may choose to write figures yourself in question 2.

Show him these cards

1

Root in the bass: root position (a).
3rd in the bass: first inversion (b).
5th in the bass: second inversion (c).

2

Figured bass counts UP from the bass note, not from the root. 5/3 = root position (usually blank). 6 = first inversion. 6/4 = second inversion.

3

An accidental in the figures changes that note. A $\sharp$ or $\flat$ on its own means the 3rd above the bass: in minor keys it's the raised leading note.



4

To read a figure: start on the bass, count up each number in the key, then add any accidental shown.



V in A minor

3 · DO TOGETHER (10 MIN)

- Take C-E-G and write it as a, b and c, with the figures under each bass note.
- Read three figured bass notes from the lesson pack and build the chords.

Four questions to work through together

1. In E $\flat$ major, which chord does this bass note and figure show?



A. Ic

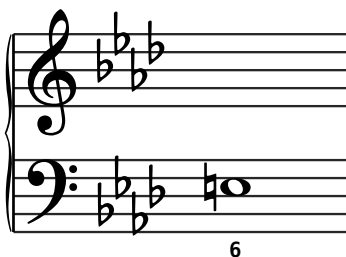
B. V

C. IIb

D. Ib

Answer: Ib. G with "6" is Ib: E $\flat$ -G-B $\flat$.

2. In F minor, which chord does this bass note and figure show?



A. IVb

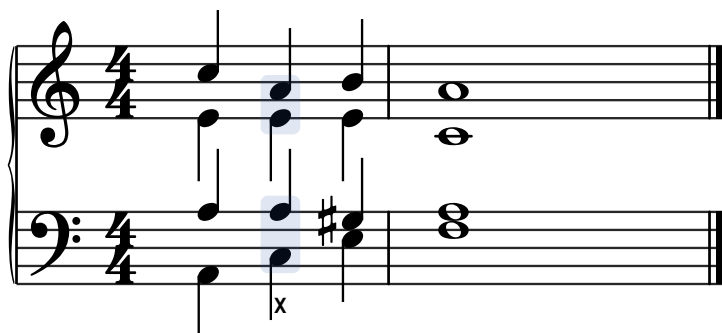
B. Ib

C. Vb

D. VI

Answer: Vb. E with "6" is Vb: C-E-G.

3. This passage is in A minor. Name the chord marked X.



A. Ib

B. VI

C. Vb

D. V

Answer: Ib. X is A-C-E with C in the bass: Ib (first inversion).

4. This passage is in E minor. Name the chord marked X.



A. V

B. I

C. Ib

D. Ic

Answer: V. X is B-D#-F# with B in the bass: V (root position).

4 • ON HIS OWN (12 MIN)

- Name 8 chords with Roman numeral and inversion letter (for example IVb), and write their figures.

His worksheet is on the next page (answers at the end).

5 • GAME (3 MIN)

Figure race: you call out a bass note and a figure; he plays or writes the chord first.

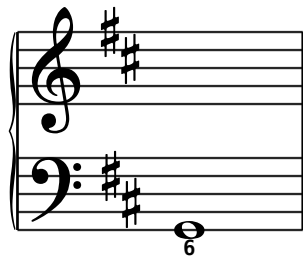
MOVE ON WHEN

He names root position and inversions quickly and can turn figures into notes in any key up to four sharps or flats.

Philip's worksheet · Day 3

Name _____ Date _____ Score ____ / 8

1. In D major, which chord does this bass note and figure show?



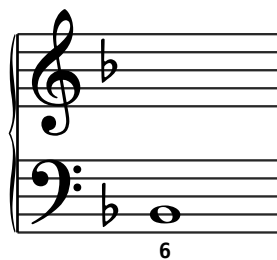
A. IV

B. IIb

C. Ib

D. Ic

2. In F major, which chord does this bass note and figure show?



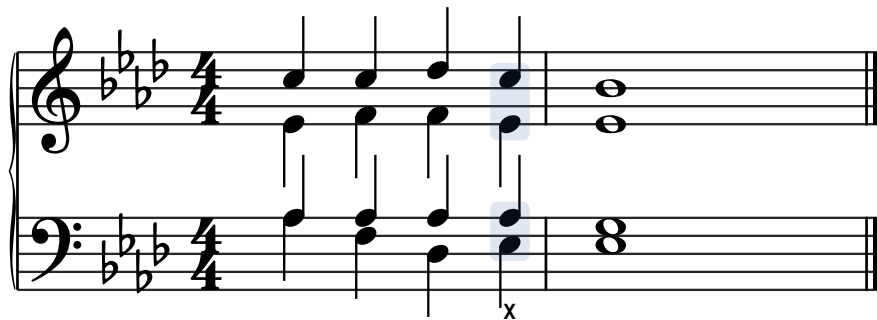
A. VI

B. II

C. I

D. IIb

3. This passage is in A♭ major. Name the chord marked X.



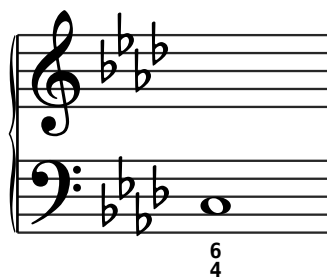
A. IVb

B. VI

C. Ic

D. IIb

4. In F minor, which chord does this bass note and figure show?



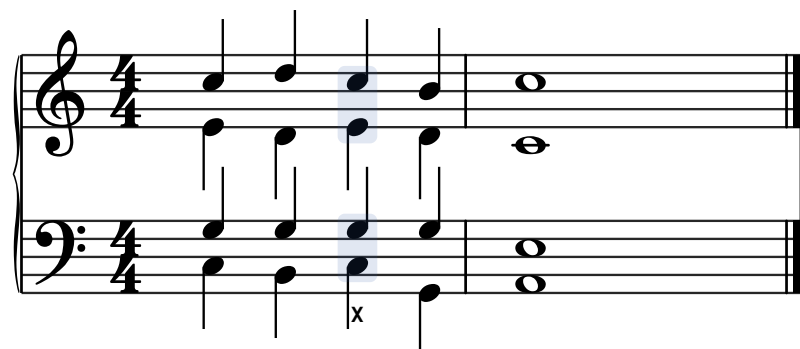
A. IIb

B. IV

C. Ib

D. Ic

5. This passage is in C major. Name the chord marked X.



A. VI

B. I

C. Ic

D. Vb

6. In A $\flat$ major, which chord does this bass note and figure show?



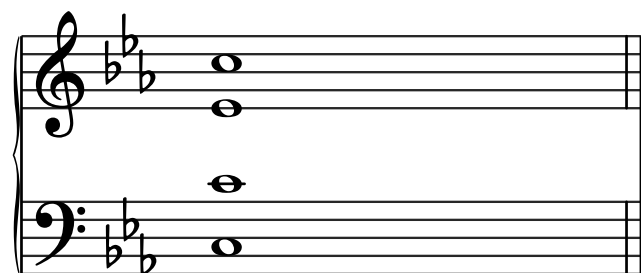
A. VI

B. Ib

C. IVb

D. IIb

7. Which figures go under this chord? (Key: C minor)



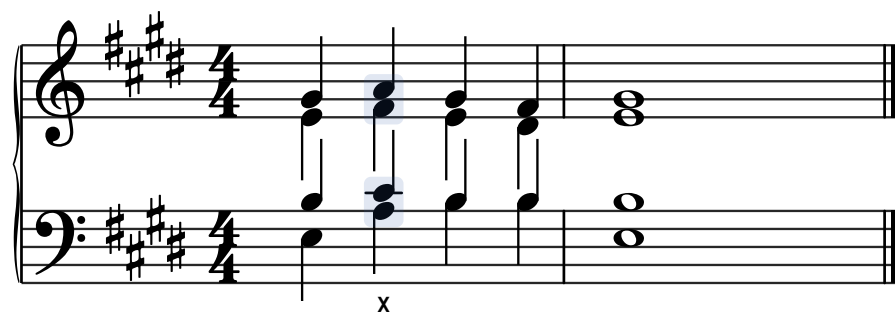
A. 5/3 (no figure)

B. $\flat 6$

C. $\flat$

D. $\flat 6/4$

8. This passage is in E major. Name the chord marked X.



A. IVb

B. II

C. Vb

D. IIb

ANSWERS (FOR MUM)

1. **B: IIb.** G with "6" is IIb: E-G-B.
2. **D: IIb.** B $\flat$ with "6" is IIb: G-B $\flat$ -D.
3. **C: Ic.** X is A $\flat$ -C-E $\flat$ with E $\flat$ in the bass: Ic (second inversion).
4. **D: Ic.** C with "6 4" is Ic: F-A $\flat$ -C.
5. **B: I.** X is C-E-G with C in the bass: I (root position).
6. **B: Ib.** C with "6" is Ib: A $\flat$ -C-E $\flat$.
7. **A: 5/3 (no figure).** The chord is I (C-E $\flat$ -G) with C in the bass. Count up from the bass: 5 and 3, which is normally left blank.
8. **D: IIb.** X is F $\sharp$ -A-C $\sharp$ with A in the bass: IIb (first inversion).

Day 4: Review: chords and figures (Days 2-3)

Bridge · about 40 minutes: warm-up 5 · teach 10 · together 10 · on his own 12 · game 3

1 · WARM-UP (5 MIN)

Today's practice in Philip's corner, or the first two 'together' questions below.

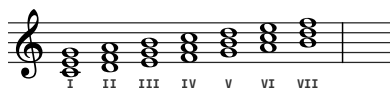
2 · TEACH (10 MIN)

- Go back over Days 2-3. Quick quiz: triads in major and minor, inversions, figures.
- Any weak spot from the check-up gets five extra minutes here.

Show him these cards

1

A triad is three notes stacked in 3rds. You can build one on every note of the scale. The Roman numeral says which note.



2

Root in the bass: root position (a).
3rd in the bass: first inversion (b).
5th in the bass: second inversion (c).

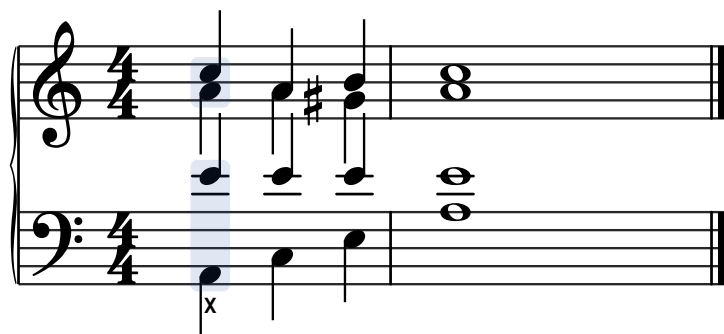


3 · DO TOGETHER (10 MIN)

- Do the 'together' questions in the lesson pack.

Four questions to work through together

1. This passage is in A minor. Name the chord marked X.



A. IVb

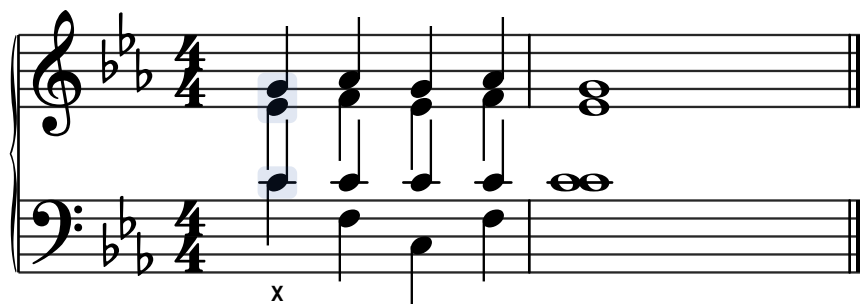
B. IV

C. I

D. VI

Answer: I. X is A-C-E with A in the bass: I (root position).

2. This passage is in C minor. Name the chord marked X.



A. I

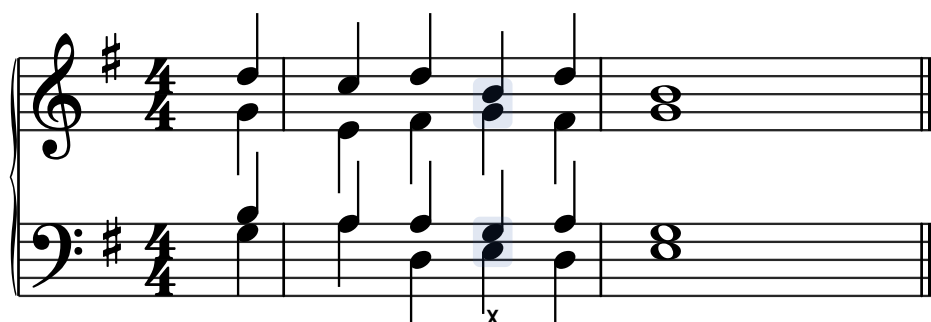
B. VI

C. IIb

D. V

Answer: I. X is C-Eb-G with C in the bass: I (root position).

3. This passage is in G major. Name the chord marked X.



A. V

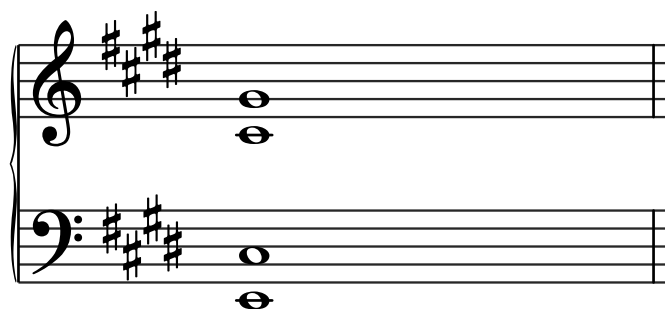
B. VI

C. Vb

D. IV

Answer: VI. X is E-G-B with E in the bass: VI (root position).

4. Which figures go under this chord? (Key: C# minor)



A. 6/4

B. #

C. 6

D. #6

Answer: 6. The chord is Ib (C#-E-G#) with E in the bass. Count up from the bass: 6.

4 • ON HIS OWN (12 MIN)

- Today's practice in Philip's corner.

His worksheet is on the next page (answers at the end).

5 • GAME (3 MIN)

Name that chord again, now with inversions.

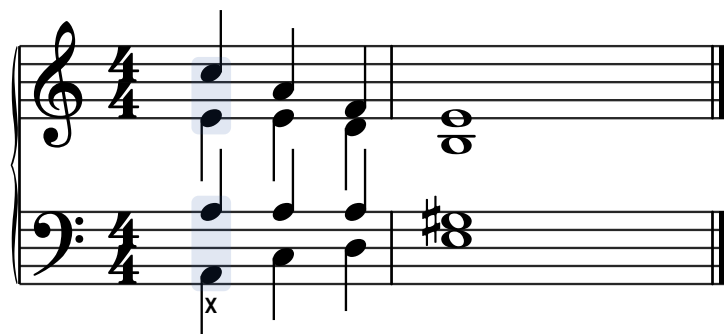
MOVE ON WHEN

8 out of 10 or better on chords and figures.

Philip's worksheet · Day 4

Name _____ Date _____ Score ____ / 8

1. This passage is in A minor. Name the chord marked X.



A. V

B. VI

C. I

D. Vb

2. Which figures go under this chord? (Key: A $\flat$ major)

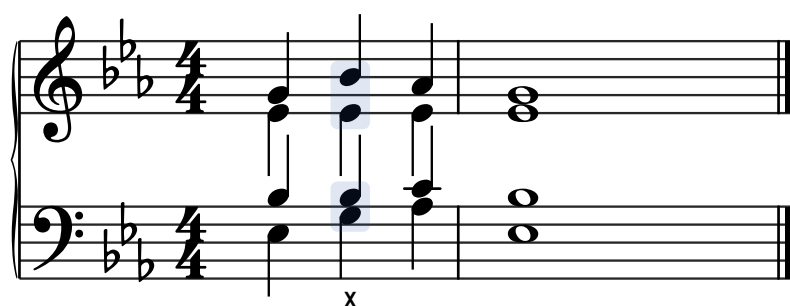


A. 6

B. 6/4

C. 5/3 (no figure)

3. This passage is in E $\flat$ major. Name the chord marked X.



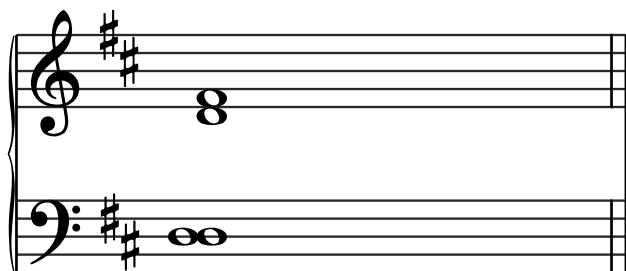
A. Vb

B. Ic

C. IIb

D. Ib

4. Which figures go under this chord? (Key: D major)

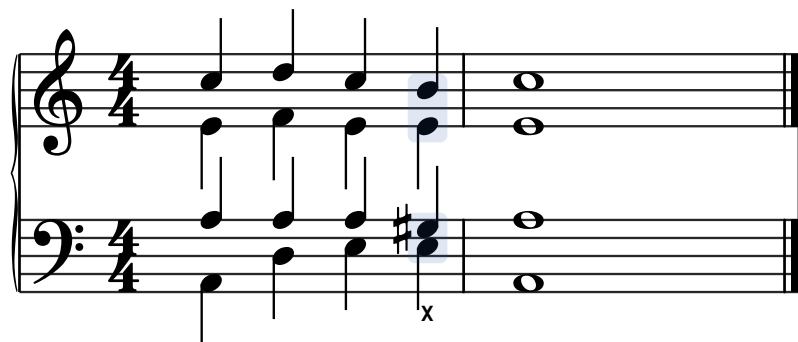


A. 5/3 (no figure)

B. 6/4

C. 6

5. This passage is in A minor. Name the chord marked X.



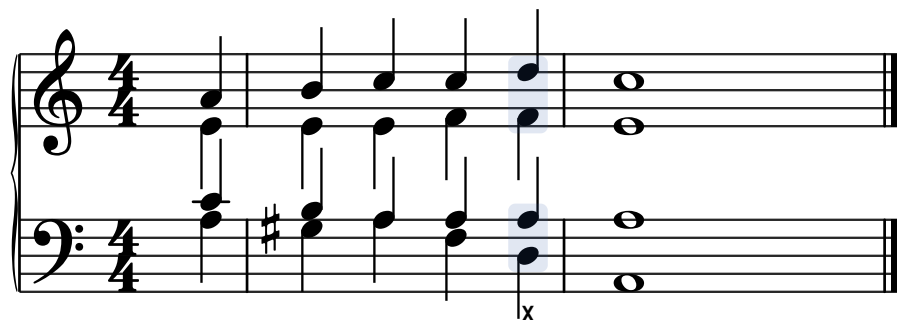
A. IVb

B. VI

C. Ic

D. V

6. This passage is in A minor. Name the chord marked X.



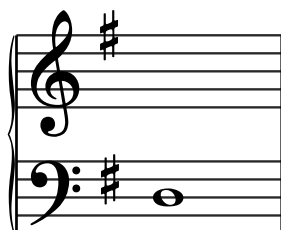
A. Vb

B. IIb

C. IV

D. VI

7. In G major, which chord does this bass note and figure show?



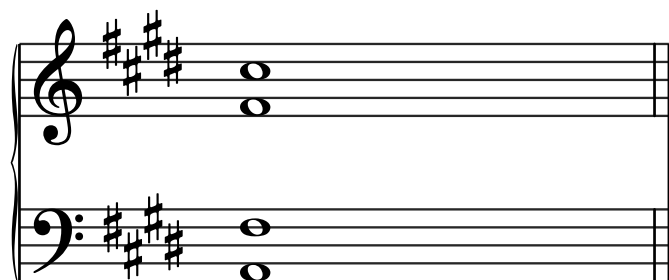
A. V

B. Vb

C. IVb

D. Ic

8. Which figures go under this chord? (Key: E major)



A. 5/3 (no figure)

B. 6

C. 6/4

ANSWERS (FOR MUM)

1. **C: I.** X is A-C-E with A in the bass: I (root position).
2. **C: 5/3 (no figure).** The chord is I (A_b -C- E_b) with A_b in the bass. Count up from the bass: 5 and 3, which is normally left blank.
3. **D: Ib.** X is E_b -G- B_b with G in the bass: Ib (first inversion).
4. **A: 5/3 (no figure).** The chord is I (D-F $\sharp$ -A) with D in the bass. Count up from the bass: 5 and 3, which is normally left blank.
5. **D: V.** X is E-G $\sharp$ -B with E in the bass: V (root position).
6. **C: IV.** X is D-F-A with D in the bass: IV (root position).
7. **A: V.** D with no figure (5/3) is V: D-F $\sharp$ -A.
8. **B: 6.** The chord is Iib (F $\sharp$ -A-C $\sharp$) with A in the bass. Count up from the bass: 6.